

# Surfin' U.S.A. -- The Beach Boys (Bass)

Bass: Harley Benton P/J, 5-string, passive. Full board.

1963. ~158 BPM (estimate).

A straight-8th boogie line borrowed from the Chuck Berry playbook. Root-fifth-sixth walks under every chord, locked to the rhythm guitar's chug.

Early Beach Boys bass is picked, punchy and mid-forward. It follows the guitar pattern rather than sitting underneath as a sub-bass thump.

The bass is most often credited to Brian Wilson on this record.

Instrument setup:

- P pickup volume: full. J pickup volume: 0.
- Tone knob: about 60%. A little rolled off, with enough top left for the pick attack.
- Play with a medium pick, between the pickups. A light palm mute at the bridge keeps the 8ths short and bouncing.

CTL off = the verse/chorus line. CTL on = a small lift for the instrumental break and final choruses.

## GP-5 settings

Module order: NR -> PRE -> DST -> AMP -> CAB -> EQ -> MOD -> DLY -> RVB.

**NR -- Gate** (always on)

- THRE: 15

Low threshold. Only cleanup between phrases. The short picked notes are already clean.

**PRE -- Micro Boost** (CTL)

- Gain: 30
- CTL off: bypassed. CTL on: engaged.

About +3dB clean lift. The line doesn't change, but the break and final choruses get louder around it.

**DST -- off**

Clean record.

**AMP/CAB -- NAM SnapTone, slot 51: CleanB15** (always on)

- Built from the `Ampeg B18 - Head DI - Bass Chan - Vol 2.5 (B-18N)` NAM and the Apg115 IR, combined into one snaptone.
- Real Ampeg B-18N fliptop (the B-15 preamp circuit), captured clean at volume 2.5, into the Apg115 B-15 cab IR.
- Period-correct: the B-15 was the standard studio bass amp in the early 60s.
- Gain: 54, VOL: 80, Bass: 55, Middle: 55, Treble: 50
- Gain 54: a little over default. This part wants more push than the other CleanB15 patches.
- Bass 55: a touch more low end.
- Middle 55: a touch more midrange.

- Treble 50: flat.
- VOL 80: the level Michael set for this snaptone in the 2026-10-02 VOL audit. Trim here if the patch jumps in level against your others.
- Same in both CTL states. AMP and CAB are off in the `.prst`, so nothing stacks on the capture. The N->S block calls slot 51 directly.

### **EQ -- Bass EQ 2 (always on)**

- 50Hz: -2, 120Hz: +2, 400Hz: -1, 800Hz: +3, 4.5kHz: -2, VOL: 52
- 2 at 50Hz takes out the 5-string's sub rumble. Nothing on a 1963 record lives down there.
- +2 at 120Hz is the punch.
- +3 at 800Hz reinforces the pick attack.
- 2 at 4.5kHz takes off pick clack, so it stays round instead of clicky.
- Same in both CTL states.

### **MOD -- off**

No modulation.

### **DLY -- off**

Not used.

### **RVB -- off**

The guitar and vocals carry the reverb on this record. Keeping the bass dry keeps the groove tight.

## **CTL summary**

- **CTL Off -- Verses/choruses.** Picked, punchy, dry boogie line.
- **CTL On -- Instrumental break and final choruses.** Same tone, about +3dB.
- Engage CTL going into the break. Drop it for the next verse. Engage again for the last chorus run and outro.

## **Full pedalboard (signal chain order)**

### **1. Flamma FS-08 Octave -- Bypassed**

- -2OCT: 0, -OCT: 0, +OCT: 0, +2OCT: 0, Dry: 100
- Footswitch off.

No octave. It would muddy a fast 8th line.

### **2. Donner Ultimate Comp -- Engaged**

- COMP: 35
- TONE: 55
- LEVEL: 55
- Mode: NORMAL

Evens out the picked 8ths so every note hits at the same level.

NORMAL mode. The pick is already putting enough attack on each note.

### **3. Donner Stylish Fuzz -- Bypassed**

- Footswitch off.

No fuzz.

#### **4. Joyo Tidal Wave -- Engaged (as a clean EQ preamp; Drive not engaged)**

- Drive: 0
- Blend: 0
- Presence: 40
- Level: 55
- Treble: 50
- Middle: 58
- Bass: 55
- Mid-Frequency: 1000Hz
- Bass-Shift: 80Hz
- Cab-Sim (DI out): Off. Ground Lift: Off. Only matters if you're using the DI out.

Blend 0 keeps the drive path out entirely. It's only used for EQ.

Mid-Frequency 1000Hz with Middle 58 pushes the finger/pick attack band. It works together with the GP-5's 800Hz boost.

Bass-Shift 80Hz tightens the low end so the 5-string doesn't boom.

Drive stays off for the whole song.

#### **5. Joyo Narcissus -- Bypassed**

- Footswitch off.

No chorus.

#### **6. Valeton GP-5 -- see settings above.**

The `.prst` only carries the GP-5's 9 modules. The pedalboard settings above are not stored in the file. Set them by hand.